there will be mountains you won't move

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38490163.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Angst, Blindness, Blood, Injury, Mutual Pining, Survival Horror, Monsters, Slow Burn, Friends to Lovers, Angst with a Happy Ending, this is going to break your heart, so bear grills has nothing on adora, more pining than survival horror i promise

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-05-01 Words: 20,688 Chapters: 1/1

there will be mountains you won't move
Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38490163.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Angst, Blindness, Blood, Injury, Mutual Pining, Survival Horror, Monsters, Slow Burn, Friends to Lovers, Angst with a Happy Ending, this is going to break your heart, so bear grills has nothing on adora, more pining than survival horror i promise

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-05-01 Words: 20,688 Chapters: 1/1

there will be mountains you won't move

by hopeisataste

Summary

because even if adora's half the reason for the hurt she's also completely the reason for the heal.

or: catra's been horribly in love with adora since before their world started to end. it would be great if she could. you know. tell adora that.

Notes

warnings: i mention injuries and blood not super graphically but graphic enough that i think if that isn't your thing you should skip this one. i have a really fluffy nice catradora fic if you'd prefer that.

me googling nerve disorders and sight loss for a fic: huh
my exams that are in a month: *HUH?????*

enjoy! :D

See the end of the work for more notes

After everything, Catra still can’t decide if following Adora was the best thing she ever did or the worst. Because knowing Adora the way she has these last couple months - tucking into her warmth, smile, personhood in such an intimate way - completed a part of her that had been absent for a very long time. Made her walk into the halls of her heart and shuffle things around a little, kick a box here, move a frame there, just so Adora could settle. Just so Catra could stop jumping in response to how her heart picked up whenever Adora would smile.

But then she remembers the newer ways she knows Adora. Knows what Adora sounds like when she’s mourning the look of something, knows the crack of her voice when she mentions they’re down on supplies, when the budding fear of having to step outside is all she can feel.

So Catra sometimes thinks, and maybe this is mean but at this point can you blame her, that this was her punishment for loving Adora too much. The universe took one look at her, with all her ageless want and care and stupidity, and said you can have Adora. Only if you have to have this, too. This fear of the night, the understanding that every time she steps outside there could be something digging into her leg, arm, biting down hard and tugging. Trying to drag her further into the woods.

They meet when Catra’s just coming into her second research trip. Freshly out of university and the first placement she picked burned. The desert. With all of its sun (that's something that the both of them mourn looking at. Perhaps for different reasons. Catra misses the sun the way you miss something that’s right next to you. She misses the light that was born out of how Adora would grow excited about their trips, or the way the lake looked, or the mess of Catra’s hair in the mornings. She hasn’t seen that sun in a long time) and heat and emptiness.

Catra remembers stepping out of her tent and standing in the pause of it all. Remembers catching the way the heat felt on her skin, hands. Grabbing at the stagnant air and running her fingers

over how smooth it was. When it gets late at night, and the both of them don't want to think about the scattered drags against their windows, the tap of something that they both know is out there, Catra will tell Adora what it was like working out in the desert. And Adora will hum against Catra's neck, will joke about what she would do for even a lick of heat now. Catra will always, inevitably, pull her closer.

But it's on that second trip, where Catra learns to love the earth for all of its difficult acceptance, that she meets Adora.

She's processing the last of the data she got on her year in the heat, going through statistics and comparing them to previous research, talking with her manager about how it could compare well to some other data they have. Her manager asks where she'd like to go next. Says that with data this good they want her out in the field as soon as possible.

Catra, thinking about the heat of the desert, decides to go colder this time. Up north, where the winters are harsh but rewarding, where catching the air in your hands is less smooth and more a shock. Where you have to chase the heat, childishly skipping and tripping over things just to tuck it against your chest to hold it there as long as possible.

Her manager explains how there's a vacancy in one of the bases far up north. Says it's one of those jobs where it's only really you and a couple other people. Catra doesn't need to hear much else. She's always been a little reckless.

Still, her manager arranges for her to meet the head of the expedition. Gets them to connect at some bar just so she can get a really good idea about how harsh this type of trip can be.

She makes sure to lay out the truth for Catra. That as much as Catra has thick skin, trips like these are the ones that can sort of strip back a person a little. Leave them open and honest and bare. Leave them lonely.

But even with that, Adora seems like the most overwhelmingly whole person Catra's ever met.

Catra arrives early and sits at the bar, fiddles with the straw of her drink, scans the room. It's a bar she would never really go to, all dark brown walls and mahogany chairs. She has to drag her eyes over things a couple of times before she can grasp the shape of them. But even with that, even with the dark and lack of light, the second Adora enters the bar Catra catches her. Scans her body, the curve of her waist, the wide of her eyes - and that hurts, somewhere dull and human - as she looks around the room, and feels a part of her split open. Yawn with admittance at the fact that, *yeah, yeah, I think we both know what this means.*

Catra likes to return to this moment when she's feeling particularly cruel. When the monsters get too much - or whatever they are. Adora always says that giving them a name means giving them power. Catra agrees. In her mind she refuses to call Adora the love of her life even though she knows it's true. She practises that self-preservation for two reasons. The first: it would make *this* a thing, give power to the animal that's settled on the edge of Catra's heart, tearing it up from the outside. If Catra started calling Adora all the names she has for her hidden in the space between her ribs she'd be unable to stop herself the next time Adora caught her hand. The second: what's life without a tomorrow? An after that? (Catra also just. Thinks she's weak. A coward. That even at the end of time, like now, she doesn't want to admit it to herself. Maybe it's because it's a confession that she's stupidly wasted all her time.)

When she returns to this moment, she asks if she would've followed Adora to the end of the earth without that initial twist in her chest. She knows, like most questions now, it's a stupid possibility to explore.

At the bar Adora is lovely and sweet and everything Catra has always hated herself for liking. The hate comes from the fact that she's never been able to grasp that same muted joy. The softness that comes with being cared for, the honeyed taste of life that

comes with never running away from things. Catra understands, even then, that she doesn’t really have a chance.

After speaking to Adora for two hours, listening to how she talks about the woods - how she’s practically a child of them, raised and nurtured and cared for. How her understanding of the earth is that it doesn’t bite back. Never has and never will. (Perhaps it’s that, that makes this whole thing so awful. That the first time the earth nips at Adora is the last time she ever gets to see it. Catra desperately tries not to think about that, even though she can hear the betrayal in Adora’s voice, so freshly juxtaposed with that night at the bar, when she talks about the outside) - Catra decides that she’ll go. Tells Adora this with an uncertain smile that vanishes the second Adora hugs her, excited. Explains how they’ll be sharing a residency a two days walk from base.

Catra knew, even then, that she had no fucking chance when it came to loving Adora. It’s nice, that that's the only prediction of hers that has ever really come true.

* * *

They've been at this point for four weeks. It's odd, that Catra hasn't thought about hope in a while. Not about preserving it, or losing it, or claiming the fleeting wisps of it that emerge every time the radio crackles to life. Catra's moved to this very vacant existence of acceptance. An understanding that they're here, now.

Adora stirs from their bedroom when Catra starts putting on her snow boots. Although leaving the house isn’t always frightening - they’re by the lake, staying in a cabin that Adora’s father built years ago, before people started leaving the area with hushed whispers for their reasons - there is always a sense of possibility

that hangs in the air. So when Adora places her hand on Catra's shoulder, Catra understands what it's a call for.

In the early morning light Adora still looks pretty. They've been running out of supplies for a while, only a few cans of things that they've been saving left, so Adora looks a little thinner than when Catra first met her. Rough around the edges. Maybe the worst thing is that Catra can't exactly say what's been making her look so uneven, what's been hurting her most. The lack of food, sleep, warmth, maybe. Throw the dice again and a thousand other reasons appear out of thin air.

Still, Catra pauses, places her hand on Adora's where it sits against the heavy coat she's wearing.

"I'm only grabbing wood," There's something in her voice, the scratch of it, that isn't born out from how early it is. "Just from the trees past the house. I know better."

"Okay," Adora says. She pauses for a moment. "I was wondering if, God, I don't know…"

Catra tips her head back so Adora can feel for her hair better. She instantly starts threading her fingers through where Catra wants them. Maybe the one good thing about living with a single person on the edge of the earth is that they know you best.

"You were wondering?" Catra's practically humming. She can feel the warmth of the action underneath her fingertips. She'll carry the feeling of this, of Adora's pretty hands in her hair, dark into the forest.

Adora starts again. Catra instantly hears it in her voice, the rawness of it, like skin after being pinched for too long, and desperately asks the universe for Adora to say something else. Ask Catra what the sky looks like, what they'll eat tonight, or anything *anything* but-

"Sometimes I feel so-"

“Don’t say useless.” Catra says fierce, anger welling up deep and sharp. “Don't you *dare* say useless.”

Catra knows it’s stupid to ask the universe for things, now. Doesn’t mean she’ll stop trying.

Ever since Adora went out into the woods - it’s been about four weeks since The Incident, all capital letters and frightening memory - things haven’t been the same. Maybe it’s because that day, where the sun sat a little too high and it was too bright for February, sunny enough that Catra had to squint to look at the lake, was the day that Catra showed Adora all her ugly messy feelings.

They don’t revisit that day often. Only in moments like these. Where Adora says something so false and awful that it curves all sick and twisted around Catra’s stomach, makes her feel so angry at herself for making Adora think she was anything but wonderful.

The arguments, or desperate attempts of Catra trying to stop herself from kissing into Adora’s lips that she *matters,* have grown more frequent the worse things have gotten.

“But it's true, isn’t it?” Adora asks, and her voice is cracking all over the place so bad that Catra has to pull her head forward, out of Adora’s grip, so she can turn to her fully. Catra catches Adora’s expression and, as much as she’s seen it recently, doesn’t quite know what to do. “I just sit here while you have to go out day after day getting stuff for us! I feel useless. I might not seem it to you but I am, okay?”

“Do I need to remind you that you’re the reason I can do like,” Catra shakes her head in disbelief, “any of this. The reason we’re alive is because of your freakish knowledge of the woods. You’re not useless.”

Catra says the last part resolutely. It doesn’t leave much room for argument but Adora still speaks. Catra can see it first in the set of

her shoulders before she opens her mouth, the way that she's looking a little bit to the right of Catra's head, hoping to catch her gaze. Trying to be brave. Catra loves her fiercely, then.

"I think we should try and get to Saul's." Is what Adora says and Catra *really* wasn't expecting that. "It's halfway to base. We stay there overnight we might have a chance to get out."

At this moment Catra hates how separate they look - her, wearing thick pieces of clothing to trap any warmth found from the inside before she goes out, Adora, wearing thick sweats and one of Catra's old worn t-shirts. Catra looks to the floor before she faces Adora's expression again, thinks that confronting this type of courage found in the set of Adora's jaw all at once could ruin her. She compares Adora's fluffy socks to her boots. Confronts what Adora's saying. She looks up. Something catches in her throat.

"It's a day's walk," Catra responds, tired. She tries to feed off the strength of Adora's expression. "For what? The possibility that nobody, nothing, is there? Is that a good idea?"

"Well, what do we have keeping us here?" Adora responds, sighs after a moment in defeat. "Catra, I've noticed that we're running out of food."

"I don't think-"

"I'm blind, not stupid." Catra flushes pink. This is a trait of Adora she loves. The transparency. The resilience. Four days after The Incident, Catra remembers how Adora turned to her from where she was resting on the bed and outlined how things might be different now, but that doesn't mean that she wants to be coddled. Catra remembers trying to tell her about the extent of her injury. Adora was resolute. "Don't act like yesterday we both ate."

"Okay." Catra says, then more defeated, "I've only done that once, though."

How the hell Adora's able to pick up on Catra cooking only one can of the food instead of two is baffling. Her guess is that Adora listened for it the way she does everything else now. She's always been good at picking things up fast. (Catra doesn't like to think about how she got the practice. How, those first couple nights after The Incident, Adora would croak out a small *can hear them, on the left.* And Catra would sit up in bed, take her hands out of Adora's hair, and look at the locked door like she'd seen a ghost.)

"Surely Saul's has more food," Adora says, resolute. "And if it doesn't it's somewhere to stay. But Catra, we *can't* live here anymore."

Catra understands the extent of Adora's ask, then. Adora grew up with summers spent in this house. When Catra first arrived and she hadn't settled in quite yet, too used to sleeping in tents that flapped with the force of hot wind, she used to find pockets of Adora around the cabin. A line indicating Adora's height on the wall left to the kitchen - they've added to it, now, when card games and sipping whisky wasn't enough against their insomnia - or a childish drawing of the lake that Catra finds behind the couch when she cleans one morning, or a necklace that Adora got for her sixteenth birthday that she still wears, something that Catra finds pressed against her chest when they sleep together.

So when Adora says that they need to leave Catra understands the urgency of the action. Adora would never want to leave this place unless she had to. And they really *really* have to.

Especially since, when Catra finally finds her way to the trees she was planning to cut, breath huffing out in front of her after getting trapped in the scarf she has pulled up to her eyes, she sees a drag of blood in the snow. Animal blood, hopefully, if Catra trusts there are people smarter than her and Adora. But the smell of it, the metallic taste that Catra has caught in the back of her mouth, makes her decide.

They can't stay here.

She gets enough wood for about two days if they're careful with it. Catra makes sure to be as quick as she can about cutting the corpse of the tree. It took her a while to learn how to do it - a morning spent with Adora before it all happened, them tracking some growth of a plant just south of their bank of the lake, Adora deciding that Catra needed to learn how to really survive out here. (It's sad, how Catra remembers how Adora's voice was filled with a joke when she said that. God they were so naïve.) Before deciding that their time was better spent with Adora teaching her the best angle of how to cut the wood. How to swing the axe just right.

But Catra's always been adaptable. Although she doesn't have the same strength as Adora she got it in the end, her back muscles pulled taught. It was rewarding, really, seeing Adora's smile after she split a chunk of pine. Same way it's rewarding now, coming home with a basket of wood and watching Adora's head turn so she can catch how the light enters the room. How she jumps up from her seat, wanting to be useful. Checking to see if Catra has any cuts by grabbing her hands and running her fingers over the rough skin.

Still, even though Catra's gotten good at being fast about it, it doesn't stop the shake of her arms. She could blame it on the cold, but there's no point in lying at the end of the Earth.

Catra thinks of the blood red against the snow. Of how they're getting closer. If anything the blood means that they're busy, preoccupied. The worst nights are when they're hungry, and Adora can hear the way they shuffle around the cabin, can catch how a branch snaps, and will pull on Catra's shirt in the darkness. Will say something about how she thinks they're on this side of the house. And the worst thing, the awful entirely inhuman thing, is that Catra understands their fucking position. The hunger has settled in her bones, too. She knows what it means, to soak into the taste of something in your mind, to haunt things for another person. She does it for Adora every day.

But even with that knowledge that they're busy, Catra makes sure that the dagger she has strapped to her leg is easy to reach, or that when she's cutting wood with the axe it doesn't get caught in the hardness of the lumber. She has rules set in her mind since Adora went out by herself for the last time. Don't look too far into the spanning trees. Sometimes you'll see things that aren't there. Or find things that could be easier left alone. Trust your mind, no matter how skittish and scared it gets. The most important; always, always have your dagger close. Lord knows Adora needed hers.

The thing about Catra, though, is that she's always been bad at following the rules. She breaks the first one often. Glances up into the space between two trees and sees beaded eyes or the flick of a tail. But as much as Catra's always been bad at following the rules she's always been brave facing the repercussions for it. She used to twitch, seize up at the sight of red or black or worse, white, the shape of it blending into the chalk of the earth around them, but now. Now when she sees dark red, a wound against the milky snow, or the shadow of movement in between two trees, a part of her says *hello.* Waves or smiles ruefully, shakes hands with death, says, *you took Adora's sight,* trembles a little in the face of so much accumulated anger, *so I won't let you take anything else.*

It's a deal, really. With death, with the monsters, with whatever nasty part of Catra exists within her. An admittance about what she can do.

This is how Catra knows. In that sharp inhale of breath, cold and brutal, about why the monsters, or whatever they are, trail around their house the way that they do. She sees herself in it. The monsters, things, figments of Catra's fucking imagination she feels sometimes, hold all the same desperation that Catra has pocketed these last few weeks. Maybe that's why she's not as afraid to meet their eyes. If anything the action alone reminds her who she is. A mirror held between them, looks suffocated in white. A parallel found underneath shared clouded vision that comes with loving something too much.

Catra runs a finger down the length of the dagger before she enters the house. She's never told Adora about the fact that they're getting closer, bolder, if the dragging blood in the snow was anything to go by. She thinks Adora can feel it besides. Thinks that the trip to Saul's is because she knows that even with the lack of food and energy supplies they didn't have that long left.

A few days ago Catra found a scratch, the length of her arm, carved into Adora's childhood treehouse. She guesses that was the final straw. This place isn't Adora's anymore.

After surveying the area around the house Catra shuffles the door of the cabin open and heaves the basket of wood inside. Starts untying her snow boots as Adora comes over.

Since Adora's lived in this house for so long she doesn't struggle navigating around it. At first, when the blindness was something Adora was still just understanding, trying to figure out where everything was exhausted her. But whenever Catra moved to help, hooking her hand underneath Adora's arm, indulging in that touch she always seems to chase, Adora would shake her off. Set her shoulders back and lift her head, turn to Catra and casually ask where an object was, like Catra couldn't hear the building frustration in her voice as she said it.

Now Adora knows the patterns of her house better. So she quickly walks over to Catra and helps her shrug her heavy jacket off. It's so awfully domestic that Catra pauses for a moment, wants to turn her head and kiss a thank you against Adora's cheek. She does not.

"So, I've thought about it and I think we should probably move out tomorrow." Adora says casually, runs a hand across the back of Catra's neck. Catra just about wilts.

"I got just about enough wood for two days," Catra responds, stands up so she can make them tea. The sun is just starting to set. "If you wanted to wait it out."

“We’ve been waiting it out for a while now.” Adora walks over and hooks her head on Catra’s shoulder after feeling for her waist. This is when Catra thinks that this whole thing was truly made to punish her. It gives the impression of stability, of pause in their lives where they can just hold each other for the sake of it, when in reality their existence is anything but that. She’s sure Adora can feel the way her neck is half burning, but Adora just carries on.

“Are we ready for this?” It's a question asked for the small of the room, half heard over the hum of the boiling water.

Catra hears it besides, hears whatever Adora has to say always. Words are precious. But Adora’s? They’re gold. Sometimes, on days where Adora has too little to say, hurting too deeply, like after The Incident when she couldn’t say anything because there wasn’t just a wound against her eyes but also her heart, Catra felt like she was chasing Adora’s words. Felt like she was hunting for riches, dragging her hand through grains of sand and sound just to find them. Just to catch the tilt of Adora’s voice against the blanket of noise from the woods.

“Do we have a choice?” Catra responds, wanting to turn her head to look at Adora but stopping herself. She knows what Adora’s expression will be - hurt, bruised. Brave too, but Catra would only really be able to find that in the cracks of her expression. It’s easier, to not look at Adora when she’s hurting. It means that Catra stops her own hurt from worsening.

Adora doesn’t say anything for a moment, shuffles Catra’s shirt up from where her hands sit on Catra’s stomach, humming into her neck an ambiguous answer. Catra nearly burns her hand while pouring the tea.

“Are *you* ready?” Catra asks, shy but understanding that this is the real root of it. The only place Adora has been in four weeks is their plot of land. For a while she liked to sit by the lake, but Catra only let her do that if she was there, watching for movement in the woods. Adora stopped doing that about two weeks ago, after the first properly bad snow.

Catra knows Adora misses the independence of the outside that she knew her whole life. But she also knows that Adora is smart. So the fact that Adora is saying they leave tomorrow is, even though Catra sometimes thinks Adora has a never ending source of courage, the final straw. Adora's ready to confront all her fears that have accumulated since the woods took a part of her.

"Do I have a choice?" Adora asks, laughs a little ruefully. Catra feels it shake against her back. As an act of restraint she moves away, carries the tea to the sofa. Adora remains standing, turns so she can address Catra as best as she can. She only starts speaking after she hears Catra drop the tea onto the table. "I just, when I was younger I never wanted to leave here, you know? I used to argue with my parents at the end of the summer saying I could take care of myself, that I could teach myself math and school and everything. And my parents would always laugh. But then I got on the research program and I *was* doing that. I was doing twelve year old Adora justice."

"That's cute," Catra says, before she can stop herself. "Little Adora thinking she can teach herself math."

"You know me!" Adora smiles, and something catches in Catra's stomach at her expression and her words. It's always nice to hear Adora say things like *that*, even if Catra sometimes fears they're not true. Perhaps it's stupid, but Catra worries the Adora she knows is only a product of her feelings. That Catra only sees the Adora she wants to see. "I was - am - *so bad* at math, I have no idea how I convinced myself I could learn it alone. But I was just thinking about that today, while you were out. Thinking about how this might be the first time I've ever wanted to leave here."

"The thought scared you," Catra says, watches as Adora's posture almost drops in defeat. The moment Catra understands that she's guessed correctly is the moment something, bold and selfish, moves to the forefront of her mind. Flicking its tail, claiming Adora like Adora isn't her own person.

“So bad, it scared me so bad.” Adora responds, words falling out of her like she’s held them in her chest for most of the day. Turned them over and inspected them to see if they, with familiarity, would grow any less painful. “But that's when I knew. We had to get out of here. Doesn’t mean my heart didn’t break and the thought but, you know, it was nice. Having some certainty for once.”

“It’s your call.” Catra says, even though she knows what she really means, the terrible truth of, *I’d follow you. However and whenever. Isn’t that awful?*

“Tomorrow, then.” Adora decides, moves to sit next to Catra on the sofa. There’s space between them that Catra knows - hopes - as the night grows colder will grow smaller.

“Do you want to,” Catra starts, unsure if this is the right thing to say purely because she can feel the way it opens up a cavern in her chest. She’s always been bad at talking about her feelings but with Adora, well. It’s Adora. (Isn’t that the fucking condition of her existence, something in Catra shouts bitterly.) She clears her throat, tries again. “Do you want to say bye to anything? In the house, obviously. You know how they get at night.”

You know how they get, always. Catra thinks but doesn't say. *You’re reminded every day. In the gap between missing sight and missing me. I know, too, how they get. I miss your smile since it happened. The one you reserved for when you really loved the look of something. Is it bad, that a part of me wants to say I saw that smile most when you looked at me? I only noticed because you don't look at me like that anymore.*

She’s taking thoughts like those to the grave. Decided on it a while ago, really. Maybe that's the deal she made with death above everything else.

“Maybe,” Adora responds, looking down as she considers what she could say bye to. Catra watches her eyelashes, moves lower, to

the scar on her cheek. “Actually, yeah. You could get some old vinyls my dad had. You know the attic?”

“You mean the place that’s scarier than the outside?” Catra deadpans.

Adora laughs. God if Catra’s heart didn’t choke at the sound.

“Hey!” She turns to face Catra fully. “I spent summers playing with my cousins up there, it’s anything but scary. If ten year old Adora can handle it, so can you.”

Catra decides to be dramatic. She knows she’s going to get what Adora wants anyway. It’s another stupid condition of her existence.

“Yeah, but you’ve always been creepily tough as nails.” Catra says under her breath. “Bet little Adora was stupid buff the way you are now.”

“Ah,” Adora breathes. Catra watches as her smile grows brash. “You finally admitted that I’m stronger than you.”

“I didn’t say *that.*” Catra replies. She only thought that in her head, maybe. When Adora used to tug supplies casually from the woods like they didn’t weigh a tonne. Or that one time - that Catra swears she doesn’t think about, she *doesn’t* - where they were jokingly fighting and Adora easily tossed her onto the sofa. Hung over her excited like Catra’s gut didn’t drop for the worst reasons the second she did it.

“You know I am, though.” Adora says, lowers her voice. “And I know you’ll get it for me besides. You’ve fought monsters before, Catra. I think you can handle a spooky attic.”

“Nope, not happening.” Is all Catra says, even though it is totally, within the next two minutes, *happening.* Her resolve against Adora has always been low.

“What? Do you need me to hold your hand?” Adora says, mocking. The second it leaves her mouth Catra shoots up off the sofa, realising, now with distance, how close their faces had gotten in the span of the conversation. She’s thankful that Adora can’t see her blush.

“Shut up,” Catra says, curt. She wonders if Adora can hear in her voice how caught out she sounds. “Where are the keys?”

“On the rack by the door I think.” Adora says from the sofa, head turned in Catra’s direction. Catra finds the keys and listens to Adora’s mocking. “Be careful, when you go up. Who knows what you could find up there. Maybe… Oh no, I don’t want to say it…”

“*Shut. Up.*” Catra grits out. Adora ignores her.

“...My sixth grade yearbook photo! Oh God, oh no!”

Adora falls dramatically onto the sofa, lays there with a hand over her chest. Catra just rolls her eyes. Says,

“I’m rolling my eyes, just thought you should know that.”

“Always so attentive to my needs.” Adora says sarcastically, sits up. Catra assumes Adora can hear her shuffle down the narrow hallway because Adora shouts through the house, theatrical. “If this is the last time I ever get to see you, Catra, there’s something I need to say.”

“You carry on with this and I am literally walking out the door.” Catra says, even though it’s a baseless lie. They both know it. Adora, again, ignores her in the pursuit of dramatics.

“I love you!”

Catra’s heart barely skips. She knows better, now, not to search for things where they aren’t.

“I hate you.”

No you don't, something bitter found in the swell of Catra's chest as she steps up the ladder shouts. *Don't even kid yourself*.

And this is why they would never work. Adora is too wonderful and understanding and good for Catra. And most importantly, she's too much of a *friend.* Adora can say that she loves Catra dramatically, honestly, childishly, and that's all it will mean. That Adora loves her. While if Catra were to say it - she has, in the past. Small and quiet, under her breath before she leaves for supplies. But Adora always catches it anyway. Will say it the same way Catra did. Catra wonders, briefly, unfair to herself, if Adora hears it in those early hours of the morning because she's searching for it. She doesn't hold onto thoughts like that for too long, returns to her senses. If Catra were to say it the way it is it would mean something awful. Her heart would slip out of her hands, fragile and wet and messy, and it would bleed out everywhere and Catra wouldn't be able to stop it, wouldn't be able to catch it and claim it back, because her and all her feelings would be bleeding too. The worst type of catharsis.

Sometimes Catra wonders when loving Adora became so twisted like this. She tries to think back to a time where it wasn't a suffocating battle between want and knowing herself. Nothing comes to mind.

Catra finds a basket in the corner of the attic - the *corner,* meaning she had to tiptoe past all the creepy toys that she *didn't* squeal at, not at *all* - filled with vinyls. She knows the record player is downstairs, so she carries the basket with her. Kicks a doll when she catches it moving in the corner of her eye. She doesn't need *another* horror movie object in her life, thank you.

Catra walks into the living room. Adora's fiddling with the survival kits on the kitchen counter when Catra comes in, recognising them by texture and symbols Catra carved into the plastic.

"Upstairs, did you drop something?" Adora asks. "I heard a thud."

Catra's mind flashes an image of a pink clad doll flying in the air to the other side of the attic.

"Nope."

"Weird." Is all Adora says for a moment. "Did you find the vinyl box alright? Not too scared by the ghost that lives up there?"

"I got the box," Catra responds. "And I didn't find anything too scary. Not even your sixth grade yearbook photo which I can only guess is the spookiest thing."

Adora sighs. "The year I got bangs. Truly horrific."

Catra places the box on the coffee table. Then she stands up, tries to find the record player. The electricity they have is from a generator Adora and her dad made when she was little. It sits up north by one of the streams, a turbine that Adora only reinforced about two years ago when she knew she was serious about staying. It's saved them more than they'd like to admit. They still have to be careful about the amount of energy they use - most of it that they had went towards keeping emergency equipment working. But they both know that now is really the only time they have to indulge. To waste things.

"Go crazy, plug it in next to the red dressers," Adora thumbs through the vinyls. "It's where my dad used to put it."

"Alright," Catra presses the plug in. "What do you want to listen to first?"

Catra moves so she's kneeling to the right of Adora, watching how Adora's fingers trace over the titles of the vinyls. She's got one of those vacant expressions, like she recognises what she's touching but can't seem to really hold it. Catra nudges Adora's shoulder, tries to bring her back to where they are. Adora turns to Catra and her expression is so dreadfully sad that a part of Catra inhales, gasps desperately and clutches at anything to make her feel better. Adora's fast with concealing her expression. Catra

hates how she can see the moment where Adora tries to plaster on a face that isn't hers.

But even with that concealment, Catra knows Adora can't lie to her.

"I just miss what they look like, that's all." Adora says, hallowed out. "I remember growing up during storms I used to pull these out and look at them for hours."

"Adora-"

"'S okay," Adora says, turns to Catra fully and smiles. A real smile. Catra thinks, the thought moulding around her ribs for the thousandth time, about how brave Adora is. "Can you find one for me though?"

"Of course." Catra responds, quick. Her hands land next to Adora's on the vinyls. She tries not to make them twitch when Adora's fingers graze hers.

"It's blue. Has a cover of a woman sitting on a chair." Adora shuffles so her hand sits under Catra's. It's not holding hands but it's something much worse. Worse in the way that Catra can feel her heart falling so many steps ahead of her. Worse in the way that Catra perfectly knows what Adora's asking.

It's something that started only recently. Adora placing one of her hands under Catra's so Catra can guide her to find something. Can hand over a bit of sight and experience that Adora doesn't have. The first time Adora did it, shy and so unlike her, Catra asked what she was trying to do. Didn't ask if she was doing it on purpose just to break Catra's heart even though that's all Catra could hear, buzz of hurt coursing through her palms. But then Adora had let out this shaky breath and said she just missed the feeling of finding something without having to run her fingers raw over it so many times. The second the explanation left her mouth Catra planted her hand over Adora's. Said nothing else. She remembers, in almost vivid detail, the exhale of embarrassed

relief Adora let out. Now the sound is imprinted in how she hears most things. The snap of a branch here to the drag of boots there.

They find the vinyl like that. With Catra's heart thumping against the walls of the house, against the walls of their friendship, asking if she does this to hurt herself on purpose.

Maybe.

Catra would be lying if she didn't see the flush spreading across her skin. She pulls her sleeves lower to her wrists when Adora pulls the record from the box. All she can hear in her mind most days is how much she likes Adora. She doesn't need it showing on her skin, too.

Catra stands up to help Adora with putting the vinyl on the player. Adora lets out this excited sound when it starts playing, all giddy and happy and Catra feels like actually breaking something then. Perhaps that's an odd response, but she hasn't heard a pure sound like that in so long that she doesn't quite know what to do with it. It hangs in the air, light and nice and so unlike the crack of every other noise.

Then Adora, the song humming behind them, turns to Catra. Offers out her hand.

Catra thinks dully, the same way she does every morning when she wakes up next to Adora, *this is going to break my heart*. *This is already breaking my heart.*

"A dance?" Adora asks, and she's smiling all stupid and happy and Catra can't say no to Adora normally but now? With Adora looking bright, like this stupid record player might give them a chance at life they haven't had these cold winter months, Catra has no chance. Catra has no fucking chance.

She's glad, for the hundredth selfish time, that Adora can't see her face as she takes her hand. She knows she must look gone or in love or a horrible mix of both. Eyes blown out, scanning Adora's

expression like she can't believe her luck. If Catra could see herself at this moment she'd laugh, scratchy and hateful.

They dance. To the last song they might ever hear, the soundtrack to longing.

At first it's swaying more than anything. Catra, still sometimes not great about people touching her, takes her time with hooking her hand around Adora's waist. They bumble around for a while with their hands connected, following the pulse of the song against the absence of pulse everywhere else this deep in the forest. But then Adora pulls her a bit closer, and Catra's hand lands on her waist and they're rocking in place and Catra's heart is really slipping out of her hands and she just. Stops caring as much. Let's herself smile, all open and sincere. Spins Adora once, twice, which causes Adora to let out a surprised laugh and tug Catra a bit closer by her waist, until their faces are close and Catra's smile moves from being ridiculously bright to mutedly sappy.

She wants to kiss Adora. But at this point that's sort of old news. Not old as in it's aged and rickety and on it's last legs but old as in it's always been there. Old as in it's wise and kind and another condition of Catra's existence.

She wants to kiss Adora.

She does not.

Instead, with their faces still so close and the jazz ringing into the almost light of the room, Adora says something that only hurts, practically whispers it into the space between their faces.

"I wish I could see what you look like right now."

They're not really swaying as much anymore, more so bodies pressed flushed together. But Catra can feel the way her heart pauses and then starts up again, hurt and running, the second the words leave Adora's mouth. There's this horrible thing sitting in Adora's expression, twisted and cruel, that's causing her to look so incredibly hurt. Catra wants to drag her fingers against Adora's

cheek, nose, run the line of where the scar is to take out whatever nasty thing was buried there on that day.

“I know you’re smiling.” Adora carries on, letting the words fill up in Catra’s chest as reasons for it to shatter. “Isn’t that awful? That I know you’re smiling but I can’t see it?”

“I am.” Is all Catra says after a moment. At first she doesn’t quite know what to do with what Adora is giving her. But she knows that when it comes to Adora it’s always best to be honest. “‘M always smiling with you.”

“That’s good, Catra, that's so good.” Adora sounds half breathless, lets her head fall against Catra’s shoulder, still swaying. “You telling me that isn’t the same, though. Still nice to hear, but.”

“I know.” Catra responds. She doesn’t know what else to do for Adora besides just being there for her. She tries that.

Adora sways with her a little longer, head resting on Catra’s shoulder. A new song starts playing and that's when Adora looks up. Her hand tightens on Catra’s waist, like she’s afraid of something, and before Catra can start stressing, can fall into the conclusion that the monsters somehow made it into the house - wouldn’t this be The Worst Moment for that - Adora’s hand moves from Catra’s waist upwards. Until it’s hanging in front of Catra’s face and she’s asking, chest cut open with the raw force of her words,

“Can I- Um, can I try something?”

Catra doesn’t exactly know what Adora’s asking to do but she nods dumbly anyway. And suddenly, against the sharp inhale of her breath, Adora’s placed her hand on Catra’s cheek. At first Catra just stands sort of paused, unable to move or think or do anything because there’s something so light, so horribly *loving,* about the way Adora is touching her. Like she’s afraid if she presses too hard, traces Catra’s freckles too fast, Catra might break. Crack open exactly where Adora touched her.

But then Adora says, and this is perhaps the worst thing that Catra has ever heard, worse than the gagging sound one of the monsters made when she slit its throat, Adora says,

“Oh,” She sounds fucked out, gone. Adora sounds like how Catra imagines her expression looks. “Oh you’re *blushing*.”

Catra barely has time to process what Adora just said, the hard mean truth of it, before Adora is pressing her other hand against Catra’s cheek, holding Catra’s burning face - and maybe that's the most horrible part about it, Catra *is* blushing*,* she’s blushing like all the blood in her body has decided to follow Adora’s thumb, running across the high of her cheekbone - and Catra’s chest yawns open. Breaks, too. But she can't hear the tell-tale crack of inevitable hurt against the force of Adora’s care. The softness of it carving into her bones.

She thinks, with Adora’s giddy wide smile and the buzz of warmth against her cheeks, *this is hurting me.*

And yet.

Catra might have this corner of the world against her, the woods, the monsters with their dragging tongues and harsh nails, but her first destroyer was always going to be herself.

So she rests her hand on top of Adora’s. Hears Adora’s breath stutter. Then Adora runs one finger across Catra’s face, from the side of her nose to just beside her ear, and Catra can feel her cheeks grow hotter and hotter but she can’t seem to care. Not when Adora already laid that ugly truth out for the room to see. Not when Catra’s heart is tired.

“Sometimes I miss your face so much I feel like I’m grieving it.” Adora says to the room, to the line of freckles she’s tracing on Catra’s skin. “Then I think I’m being stupid. Because of all the things to miss, of all the things we don’t have right now, I pick something right next to me? You see how stupid that is?”

Catra can’t move. Maybe it’s because there’s a slap to Adora’s words, like stepping into the cold of a morning and feeling it bite back against your skin, like it’s too early for the earth to decide to accept you. Maybe it’s because she’s lessened her grip on Adora’s hand and is slowly coming to her senses. Is starting to realise that maybe, unlike all the other times Adora has touched Catra, she won't be able to recover from this.

Before she can step away, can say something about cooking dinner or wasting electricity or anything mundane and easy, Adora’s thumb travels down her face. Until it hovers over her Catra’s bottom lip, and Catra’s pulse is beating so hard that she’s sure Adora can feel it, but there’s something in Adora’s expression, like she’s drawn to what she’s doing - *drawn to Catra’s lips,* and Catra tries not to think too hard about that – that means that Catra thinks Adora wont notice.

Adora presses down on Catra’s lip slowly, like she’s afraid it might burn her skin, easing herself into it. But suddenly, before Catra can even mentally prepare, Adora presses down properly, runs across Catra’s bottom lip. And then Catra makes this awful embarrassed sound, something born out of a want she has carried through the night for months now, something born out of Adora’s hooded gaze, and Adora jumps back. Like Catra’s lips really did burn her. Like touching Catra is an action that's going to leave her bruised.

The look on Adora’s face leaves Catra’s heart split open like rotten fruit.

She’s ruining them.

“Oh my god,” Adora says, steps back again. “God, sorry I don’t even know why I-”

“It’s okay.” Catra says, even though it’s not. Even though she knows she’s going to have a hard time mending herself from this. “We should start packing.”

There’s a distance in Catra’s voice that she’s scared of. She expected, the second she opened her blessed mouth - because it’s something holy, now that Adora’s touched it. Catra needs to reconsider what this has become. Needs to take Adora off the pedestal because look where that's got her. Thinking of Adora's hands as sources of blessing? - for her voice to sound the way that she looks, feels. But instead she sounds normal. Confused, maybe, if Adora is able to catch it in the odd absence that Catra’s voice has. She sounds like she’s taken a step outside of her body and decided that that moment wasn’t really hers. Decided that maybe it was just something born from her head. She’s dreamt things like that before.

“Yeah, I’m okay, okay.” Adora says, muddled. She pauses, like she’s listening for the beat of Catra’s pulse or the fast pace of her breathing. She doesn’t find it. “What should we start with? Um, we have the kits and-”

They don’t talk about it. Catra doesn't sleep. The only change she notices is that when Adora falls into bed later, tired and exhausted, she doesn’t curl into Catra the way she usually does. There’s a gap of space between them that hasn’t been there for a long time. She feels like she’s choking the second she realises it, feels like her heart is trying to tug its way up her throat.

They don't talk about it.

She’s ruining them.

* * *

When Catra pulls herself out of bed the next day the room is dark. Something else is, too, buried in the way that she lightly shakes Adora’s shoulder to wake her up instead of running her hands through her hair.

Adora stirs far too quickly for Catra to believe that she was actually asleep. She tries not to dwell on what that means for too long.

Instead, they get ready. They double check everything that they put into the bags last night - safety kits, weapons, clothes and food. Adora's pack carries the tent if they need it (Catra's praying that they won't) and Catra's carries all the essentials. They've separated the items out equally. Catra tried to secretly pack more things so Adora's bag was lighter.

Catra dresses slowly, picking out the clothes that she knows are the thickest and warmest. She doubles up on layers, makes sure that she has a spare set of gloves in case she loses the ones she usually uses. She's not exactly in the mood to lose a finger to the cold right now. Catra prepares in a simplistic methodical way. It's less like she's leaving and more like she's waiting for the arrival.

Adora prepares saying goodbye to the house. She sits on the sofa staring forward. Catra doesn't know why she's preparing in such a weirdly sad way but she has a few guesses. A more melancholy part of her wants to say that Adora is memorising the feeling of the room, the smell, the way that the size of it changes the second a dash of light falls through the window. But the honest part of her knows why Adora is sitting like this, staring at the wall. Catra knows Adora is conjuring up every single image she has of the monsters and the outside in order to prepare herself for it. Trying to rip off the band aid before it happens.

Because they will encounter some of the monsters. They both know that. Catra's got daggers strapped to both legs.

Catra's packing the last of things at the counter when Adora calls her over. She's still sitting on the sofa but she's not staring forward anymore (Catra stops herself from exhaling in relief), instead she's holding something in her hands. Catra only sees it after she's walked over, standing in front of Adora. The second she does see it her gut drops, her hands remember.

“It’ll be easier,” Adora explains, fiddling with the bandage in her hands. “If I wrap this around my eyes. The lights and shapes can be confusing sometimes. Do more harm than good.”

“Okay, yeah. Sure.” Catra says, even though she wants to touch literally anything else - probably the monster’s knotted skin, instead of this. But she kneels in front of Adora besides, prys the bandage out of Adora’s grip.

She tries to stop her hands from shaking. She knows Adora will be able to feel it against her skin, will be reminded of weeks ago when this was a daily ritual. Catra stops shaking for the sake of that. She knows Adora, above everything, doesn’t want to revisit those days.

“The skin isn’t freshly cut anymore so you can tie it tighter,” Adora says. Catra can feel the first streaks of sunlight against her back. A message that they don't have that much time.

Catra moves to tie the bandage around Adora’s eyes. Takes the two ends and pushes forward on her knees, until she’s able to reach the back of Adora’s head. She’s just about tied the first knot, about to ask Adora if it’s too loose, when she focuses her eyes.

It shouldn’t be surprising, how close Adora’s face is. Catra can scan the dips and curves of her skin, can intimately see the scar against her cheek. Their faces are close, if not closer, than last night. Catra’s hands are still hanging dumbly around the bandage at the back of Adora’s head. She thought her heart would grow tired of running, sprinting, the way it always does in moments like these. It’s clear, from the way she can hear the pulse in her ears, something flicking its tail in her stomach, her body has not grown out of this.

A mean part of her, something cutting and cruel, debates pressing her forehead against Adora’s. Their faces are so close and after last night - after all the nights, after Adora has whispered so many honey sweet things into Catra’s space for what feels like decades,

lives - can you blame her? Catra wants to thank Adora, press their foreheads together as an attempt to say all the pretty things she's wanted to for so long.

But she knows that would give a thousand reasons of break for the both of them. Would remind them of weeks ago.

* * *

The day Adora loses her sight is a day that sits in Catra's mind, angular and sharp, pressing into every moment where Catra feels like being greedy, or stupid, or in love, and makes her pull back.

It's the day she finally understood how selfish she was. How much that selfishness was ruining everything. Ruining them.

It starts normal. Maybe that's the most haunting part of the memory. Adora and Catra spend the morning exploring a plant species just outside of their plot of land, farther south. Adora's visited this area before - she found the plant species while on a walk, radioed Catra at home all excited about it since it could contribute something to their research. Catra, in the comfort of Adora being not able to see her, pulled all the sappy faces imaginable. Said that they'd visit it two days from then, tilt of reservation in her voice like she wasn't falling half in love with Adora's excitement.

Catra and Adora head out early in the morning. It's not a serious trip so they don't bring much with them. They both know they don't plan to spend long up on the hill, plan to find their way back for a slow lunch outside.

It's scary, how comfortable their life used to be. How the outside was accepting and nice and nothing of what it is now.

Catra could convince herself that she took it all for granted, but she knows she didn’t. She fell in love with Adora the same way she fell in love with the Earth. She knew then how much it mattered. How special the Earth was. Adora taught her in the splash of the lake skipping rocks, or in the rise of the tired sun, warmth stretching across her tan skin in the mornings, warmed, too, by the drag of Adora’s hand across her stomach.

They reach the plant area - it’s pretty deep in some woods just off the incline of the hill. Catra notices how she has to adjust her eyes to see better. The trees jut out like cuts in the earth. There’s far too many of them but also not enough to stop what feels like pauses in her vision, gaps where the trees weren’t able to fit around the break. She turns back to Adora, who’s touching the plant stems, muttering something about how it’s similar to another plant north of the lake, which is odd.

Catra contributes the minimal information she has about what that could mean and Adora nods, stands up. Catra self-indulgently catches onto her smile first, the flush of her skin from the growing cold next, then Adora’s eyes - unhurt and blue, so blue that Catra feels, now, that she might search for that colour for the rest of her life, hidden in a pocket of the sky there to a dip of the lake here - until her gaze falls into one of the gaps between the trees.

Catra, in the brief moment she has to look, spots something black. Beaded red eyes. Claws, maybe. She doesn't exactly remember what the monster looks like and she can't trust herself to not form that version of it from the knowledge she has now. Catra only recognises it as a blotch of dark against the earth. A splatter of paint that isn’t stagnant, paused, but moving closer. Fast. Dragging its claws against the ground but still managing to keep up.

The look doesn’t last long enough for Catra to pull Adora out the way. So when Adora does turn around to where Catra was looking, gaze initially fixed on Catra’s expression, confused, the monster jumps.

Catra hears the rip of skin before she sees it.

Hears Adora’s cry, then. (Hears Adora’s cry for a long time after.)

Adora falls backwards, head in her hands, the start of the blood dripping down her palms, through the cracks between her fingers. She’s crying red. Catra’s gut drops in the most horrendous way, makes her want to scream all childish and scared and run in the opposite direction. But something steps up in that moment, too. Born from knowing Adora first and her bravery second.

Catra pulls Adora up from off the ground. The blood has started running down her arms and Catra can feel the wet of it when she pulls Adora by her sleeve. She tries not to think about that. Instead, she runs. Adora’s stumbling, falling forward at each step, gripping Catra’s arm like Catra’s life herself.

Catra can hear the drag of the monster, thing, behind them. Can hear the way the trees cut around their movement and its. She knows that they won't be able to outrun it. Not really.

So she presses Adora against the bottom of a thick tree they pass. Pauses and runs her finger down the knife she has strapped to her leg. Before she turns to walk away, she takes one last selfish action, takes Adora’s head in her hands, memorises the curves of Adora’s face, and presses their foreheads together. Adora’s crying blood but Catra does it besides. Leaves Adora’s cheeks painted by the imprint of her bloody fingers.

Says I love you. Says goodbye.

Says none of that at all.

Catra tracks back the way that they came. A plan forms in her mind and she decides to commit to it. It’s loose and barely there and probably won't work but the image of Adora’s face is keeping her going. Making her push forward, stand behind a tree they crossed earlier.

The plan goes like this: Catra is going to let the monster pass her - hopefully it won't catch onto her smell or the way that her heart is beating so horribly - and will find its way to Adora. Then Catra's going to wait until it's distracted by Adora's smell, or the taste of blood, or the fact that she's the perfect image of its power, and jump behind it. Stab it anywhere she can reach.

She doesn't expect it to work.

It does.

Catra jumps behind the monster just as it's turning to look at Adora sitting against the tree. She has the knife in her hand, rubbed red. It's something she usually uses to cut up fish, rope. Catra stabs deep in the back of what she thinks is the monster's neck. Her vision is blurred but she hears a choking sound from the monster, a gagging breath it takes before it falls. At the final moment, after its neck twitched with the way Catra pulled the knife out from it, the monster turns. Moves its head to her and Catra can see the way the strands of its muscles are stretching with it, rejecting the movement, pulling apart and falling like pieces of red ribbon. It catches her eyes once before it falls. Catra holds its gaze, chest heaving.

The fall of its body is heard with the shout of Adora. Catra runs over as fast as she can. Adora's bleeding has gotten worse, tainting her skin fully red now, the depth of it against the soft of her cheeks. Catra takes off her jacket, presses the fabric against Adora's face and ties the arm sleeves around the back of her head to catch the bleeding. She can't see how bad it is against the amount of blood the cut is drowning in.

Adora makes this small sound, the strike of it tearing against her throat, pain lacing into the way the words tilt against her tongue. She says,

"Catra,"

And Catra doesn't need to hear much else to know that it's bad.

Catra knows all the ways that Adora has said her name, has cruelly memorised them - whispered in the darkness of their bedroom after another scratch against the window, happy about the sun hitting the lake and the water up to their ankles, frustrated after Catra forgets to put things back to where Adora can find them - but Adora has never *never* sounded like this.

She sounds desperate. Sounds like her heart is giving out. Catra's mortified by the way she recognises the familiar ring of that exhaustion from her own chest. Catra's the most horrified by the way her voice sounds as she's calling for Adora. If Adora was any more conscious surely she would pick up on how Catra sounds ruined. Would glance at the floor and notice that Catra's heart was left there at her feet, bruised and choking.

"No, no, come *on* Adora," Catra solely speaks to the silence of the woods judging by how Adora's neck is hanging. "Come on get up, *please Adora,* oh fuck, fuck-"

"Catra?" Adora lifts her head. Her face is buried in Catra's stupid shirt so at first the words are hard to hear. Catra catches them anyway. She always does.

"Adora," Catra starts. She tries to make herself sound more casual than she feels. She knows Adora would start to panic if she caught onto how awful things seem. Are. "Hey Adora, let's stand up," Adora shakes her head. Catra can see the way the muscles in her neck are taught with pain. "Come *on,* Adora, don't you *dare*-"

At the scratch of Catra's voice Adora shuffles up until she's standing. Catra can tell from the set of her shoulders that the movement alone put her through a ridiculous amount of pain. Catra can hear the snap of a branch far away, the drag of a claw that follows it. Adora leans against a tree, looks like she's going to pass out.

"Adora," Catra starts again. She wonders when she started saying Adora's name like a prayer. "Adora come *on,* let's get out of here and then you can rest at home. Let's go, *please,*"

Adora’s back gives out and she nearly crashes to the floor again. Catra catches her arm, pushes her against a tree and keeps her there. Adora’s words grow more slurred as she tries to fight out the next sentence. Catra can see the first blotches of red find their way to the top layer of the fabric of her jacket, mocking.

“Home,” Is all Adora says, and then she looks up and all Catra can see is where her bloody thumb pressed a mark against Adora’s jaw. “You promise?”

“I *promise.”* Catra’s voice sounds airy, worn out.

Adora nods, lets out a shaky breath that catches onto the trees and hopefully stays there. Catra doesn’t want to bring that exhaustion, or any of this day, back home.

The second Adora nods Catra takes her hand. She feels the way blood is trapped between their two palms. Catra’s is the blood of the monster, spitting out the moment she pulled the knife from its neck. Adora’s is her own. It’s the latter that makes Catra feel sickest.

Catra debates carrying Adora on her back but she just knows that will make them slower - Adora’s all muscles and Catra’s quick on her feet but that's only because she’s light. She knows if she carried Adora she would trip on the first jut of a root against the earth and the monsters would find them like that, fallen and curled into each other, the same way they sleep.

So Catra starts dragging Adora by the hand the way they came up through the woods. At first they’re both stumbling, Adora obviously dizzy by how fast Catra is pulling her along and how the earth is jumping out at them, making Catra’s ankle roll in an almost dully painful way. Everything else sort of pales in comparison to how Adora’s making these small sounds, private confessions of pain she’s running away from, trapping in the exhale of breath. Catra hates how Adora is thinking of hiding her pain even now. But she also understands that, if Adora were to yell the way her chest and eyes and heart want her to, the

monsters would find them almost immediately. They wouldn’t have a chance.

Catra finally sees the gap of trees that open up to the path and stumbles disastrously towards them, tugging Adora by her arm. From this point it’s not that far of a walk, or run, or whatever is the way Adora is moving right now. Messy steps that make her look like she’s only just discovered that she has legs. Because the rest of the trip is downhill Catra pulls Adora forward by her wrist, until Adora is standing just in front of her.

Catra does a quick glance back, notices how the woods aren’t shaking with the force of something flicking its tail, and says,

“Let me carry you,” Adora tilts her head, loose. Catra tries to keep her awake. “Adora I’m gonna carry you, it’s downhill so I should be able to do it.”

Catra grabs Adora’s arms and swings them around her neck, squats so Adora can hopefully jump on her back. Right now speaking to Adora feels like speaking to a wall, or a fading light. Catra knows the blood has stopped flowing so fast by the way that the cloth around Adora’s eyes isn’t drenched with it. But still, they don't have much time. Adora jumps onto her back just at the moment Catra starts to doubt this working. Catra makes sure Adora’s hands are linked against her sternum before she starts walking as fast as she can.

Catra was right about Adora’s muscle accumulating into weight. She can feel the burn in her legs and the way that Adora’s neck is drooping against her shoulder, lifeless. It causes her to pick up the pace, until she’s half running down the hill to their corner of the lake, the sight of the house forming in front of her like some sort of awful nightmare. The promise of it there without the certainty of its presence.

They reach the house and Catra collapses against the door. She kicks it open and locks it behind her with all of Adora’s weight on her back. Adora lifts her head slightly, recognising the change in

smell or light maybe, and breathes a *home* into Catra's neck. If Catra's nerves were any less fried she'd wilt from that alone. Instead she walks to the sofa, leans until Adora can lie down comfortably. The way her weight falls tells Catra enough - she doesn't have that much time.

Catra darts around the kitchen until she finds the survival kits. Washes the blood off her hands. She did a course on injury training before she left - nothing major, certainly nothing that prepared her for *monsters* - but it taught her about how to clean a wound and what to do in situations like frostbite and hypothermia.

She's so glad she listened when the instructor took her through animal cuts. Adora's half twitching against the sofa, the pain still drawing its way down her spine and sticking there, taunting. Catra kneels on the floor next to the sofa, puts the survival kit on the coffee table and threads her hand through Adora's. Adora makes another small sound that has Catra grip harder, course her fingers through Adora's hair and whisper about how things are going to be okay. Perhaps Catra should care that in every motion of trying to resolve Adora's hurt she's letting her tangled feelings spill out everywhere, messy and childishly young. She doesn't find time to even care about it, too exhausted by the walk and the sound of Adora's skin tearing.

"Adora," Catra starts, running a thumb down the bridge of Adora's wrist. "Adora, `m gonna take off the shirt tied around your eyes, okay?" Adora's head is lolling, but Catra can catch the way she nods.

Catra takes her hands out of Adora's hand and hair and Adora makes this sad sound that Catra forces herself to ignore in favour of unravelling the knot of fabric at the back of Adora's head. It falls apart quickly, Catra only having to pull at the strands for a moment. And when it falls it falls messy and mean.

The monster didn't cut just directly across Adora's eyes but under it too, the swell of both her cheeks. Catra realises how big the

hand of the monster was, then. The cut is a fresh red, the look of it reminding Catra of torn raw meat. She tries not to throw up. Instead, she opens the box and sanitises her hands. Grabs one of the ointments and disinfectants and tries to conjure up the image of how the instructor did it.

The second Catra floods the cut with disinfectant Adora screams. Harsh and clawing its way up her throat, it's the scream that Adora stopped herself from making in the woods. The sound of it leaves Catra both full with panic and hollowed out with fear. Catra thinks Adora might pass out from the pain from the way her back is curving up with the force of it, the way her arms are almost twitching, wanting to drag Catra's hands away from her face. Catra sets her shoulders, continues to clean and wrap the wound as best she can.

It's an agonising hour for the both of them. Catra thinks, against Adora now passed out on the sofa, half her face wrapped up in gauze, that she will find all the sounds of pain Adora made in every piece of music or scratch of noise she hears next. It's sad, that that used to be the condition when it came to Adora's laugh. Catra would find the laugh laced into all her favourite sounds - that song she liked when she was sixteen and her music taste was abysmal, the shake of a tree just east of the lake, its roots leading back generations - but she knows this day has changed her. Changed the both of them, judging by the way Adora's eyes looked.

By the way that, before Catra wrapped the gauze, Adora let out a choked *can't see you, why can't I see you?* And Catra's heart broke.

Catra tries to stay attentive to Adora's needs while she rests on the sofa, bringing her water and sometimes waking her up to take the pain medication Catra finds in the back of one of their cupboards. Catra eventually falls asleep on the floor, ready to bounce into action the second that Adora makes so much of a noise of discomfort. Adora's practically passed out when Catra falls asleep. She's breathing, thankfully - Catra listens for the pockets

of sound almost desperately against the silence of the room, grabbing them and pulling them close to her chest like they're promises that things will get better.

She's stirred awake after a few hours by Adora saying her name, lips chapped. Catra sits up immediately, runs a hand through her hair and grabs the water, presses it against Adora's lips. Adora seems to be recovering, the blood loss and drugs making her hazy. She's present, though. Catra can see the way parts of her are forming again, the way bravery is dragging back to life within her as she sits up. Catra pushes her down against the bed again by her shoulders.

"Just," Adora starts, the words barely there. "Can you wash all this blood off of me?"

Catra takes a cloth from the kitchen and douses it in water. She walks over to Adora again, careful to avoid getting the gauze wet, and drags the cloth down Adora's face. Until where Catra's bloody hands pressed into her isn't a mark anymore, or Adora's own blood can't be found in the cracks of her skin. Adora seems half out of it, but she lets out a small *thank you,* when Catra finishes.

She falls asleep for a few more hours. Catra showers, makes some lunch, checks Adora's temperature for infection and watches the sunset from the windows. She has no idea about the next time they might be able to leave.

When the house is bathed in darkness, Catra only keeping a reading light on near Adora's sleeping figure, Adora sits up. Catra tracks the movement from where she's sitting on an armchair opposite, stands up quickly when she sees Adora try to shuffle herself off the sofa.

"Rest," Catra says, watches as Adora turns her head towards her. The angle is off, Adora looking a little bit too far to the right. "Adora please, you're hurt."

"'S uncomfortable," Adora's words scratch around her chest, harsh. Catra knows it's taking her a lot of effort to be somewhat comprehensive.

"I could carry you to bed?" Catra asks, and then realises what she just said with dull embarrassment. Her face heats up, skin grows hot, but she still shuffles closer to Adora. Adora's nodding, muttering a quiet *yes* under her breath, almost sleepy. Catra moves to the same position she did in the woods, the action dawning on her like her body has become a ghost, hooking Adora's hands above her sternum and letting Adora jump on her back.

They've made it down the hallway, only a few steps away from their bedroom, when Adora kisses Catra's neck. Catra's breath hitches. A moment after she does it again, just below Catra's ear. Slow and wet and dragging, Catra nearly trips, makes this surprised sound that she never wants to hear come out of her mouth again. She pauses in the darkness of the hallway, the light of the bedroom flooding around them, and asks, voice broken, so so broken that Catra's sure she's never heard herself sound this way. She asks,

"Adora," She grips Adora's thighs tighter. "Adora, what are you doing?"

Adora plants one more kiss against the side of Catra's neck before she speaks.

"Just wanted to say thank you," Her words are slurring. "'S all."

Catra remains paused in the hallway, standing just before the door of their shared bedroom. Adora seems content, passive, like the fact her kissing Catra's neck didn't fundamentally change things, didn't make the planes of their friendship shift in confusion. Adora kisses her neck like she's done it before. Has tucked all her warmth and love into Catra's skin like that a thousand times in the past, in the series of lives before this one.

Catra thinks that what hurt, hurts, most is that Adora did it so casually, so open with the promise of another chance. That, if Catra didn’t stop, didn’t grip Adora tighter in confusion, Adora would kiss her again. Against the back of her neck, behind her ear another time, just to be sure. The awful truth is that Adora can kiss her on the neck and it doesn’t mean that a part of her is lost to the action. Catra can't say the same.

Catra comes back to her senses, walks into the bedroom and places Adora on the bed. Before she leaves to go grab the supplies Adora hangs on, drags her hand down Catra’s arm until she reaches the wrist, pulls forward.

Catra wonders if this day was truly made to punish her. (It is here that the dull thought of *this is hurting me,* grows mean and tangled from the earth. Already hungry before it broke the ground, it's a thought that stays with Catra for a very very long time.)

Catra’s standing in the open of Adora’s legs as she sits on the edge of the bed. She has no clue what Adora’s asking, her hand firm on Catra’s wrist. A part of her wants to pull at Adora and yell, scream about how this is hurting her, about how she can’t do it anymore. But she stays. Still worried that Adora might need something or ask for more medication. Instead, Adora says nothing, runs her thumb against the jut of Catra’s wrist.

The action lulls Catra until she’s close to falling asleep. Adora carries on rubbing her wrist, moving to drag her fingers up Catra's arm. At that moment Catra just. Wants to make Adora *feel* good. Wants to give Adora the comfort Adora is giving her, remove all the hurt and confusion of the last few hours.

So she does something stupid, entirely born from the moment and the fact that Catra’s been in love with Adora during all the others.

She ducks her head, until her and Adora’s faces are aligned. And it must be something in the night, in the barely there light of the room, in the fact that Catra misses Adora’s face wrapped under

the stupid gauze, because she kisses Adora's jaw. Hangs there after a moment like she needs to pause from how overwhelming the action was. Adora doesn't stiffen, or push Catra away, or become any of the images that Catra's mind has conjured up every time she's come close to this.

Instead, Adora *sighs.* Ducks her head and breathes,

"Thanks,"

Catra just dumbly nods, even though Adora can't see it. Whispers something sharp and barely there about grabbing the kits and medicine from the kitchen. Adora falls back on the bed, hums.

* * *

They don't talk about it.

Catra doesn't know if Adora even remembers.

If she did. Well. Then Adora *knows.* She has to. Maybe that's what's made every soft moment with Adora since then quietly cruel. Adora knows Catra loves her but she still lets Catra be selfish, still lets Catra touch her in all the mean little ways Catra's always wanted to.

That's when the ruining things started, Catra thinks bitterly. Just if you were wondering.

* * *

Catra ties the last knot, pulls back. Announces that they're leaving in twenty minutes. Adora nods, her skin a flushed soft pink. Catra

assumes it's from how she tied the wrap tighter than usual.

Catra gathers the last of their things, drags the packs they have to the door and shrugs her heavy coat on. Adora does the same, her coat a charcoal grey. Catra goes to the kitchen to grab the rope. The rope is an idea born from practicality and the awful truth that Adora can't walk too long on the terrain outside without falling. She makes sure not to say that out loud, though, even though they both know that's why they need it.

Adora is fiddling with her gloves when Catra walks over.

"Got the rope," she says, holds it out so Adora can feel the ridges of its twists. "I think if I tied it around your waist and then mine it could work."

"Sure," Adora responds, looks up. Catra catches onto how the length of the excess bandage swings behind her head, misses her face. She feels foolish. "It might not work super well though. I'll trip."

"You might not," Catra responds. Adora tilts her head, amused.

"I will," She smiles. "Sweet of you to think I won't though."

"Just come here," Catra says, faking annoyance, dragging Adora forward by her belt loops. Adora's smiling and Catra's trying not to think about it, even as her hands sit on Adora's hips as she gets ready to tie the rope around Adora's waist. Adora's face is a tad bit pink still, and Catra knows that the same colour is dancing around her expression, hitting a freckle there before falling short, shy.

Her hands move from the flat of Adora's hips to the pinch of her waist. At this point surely, *surely,* she should be desensitised to touching Adora like this. For weeks she woke up with her hand subconsciously thrown over the curve of Adora's waist, would have to move her nose out from where it was pressed up against the back of Adora's neck. You would think that that would offer

any sort of consolation or preparation for moments like these. It doesn't. Catra's hands burn.

"Okay," She says, voice a little shaky. "Zip up your coat so I can tie it properly,"

"Yes sir," Adora says, joking.

"I'm just gonna wrap it around your waist, alright?" Catra responds, pulling nervously at the rope in her hands. "Tell me if it gets too tight."

"You say that too much," Adora responds. "Seems like all you do is tie me up."

"Adora," Catra says, choked.

"What?" She tilts her head, smirks with realisation. "Oh, ha. Didn't peg you for the type to be into that."

"*Adora,"* Catra breathes, cheeks flushed. Her hands pause on Adora's stomach.

"Sorry! You just don't seem like it," Adora doesn't elaborate on why and Catra's thankful she doesn't. Does that mean that. What? Adora's thought about what she likes? The notion alone is so dizzyingly awful that Catra has to take her hands off of where they sit against Adora's hoodie, threading the rope.

"Does that feel okay?" Catra steps back, breathing in the space between them. She didn't realise how close they were until Adora said, well, *that.*

"Think so, it doesn't pinch at my waist too bad," Adora turns to her, the rope dragging on the floor. Catra is still blissfully feet away from her. "We have to do you too, right?"

"Yup," Catra responds, moves to sarcastic as a way to distract from how Adora's smiling. "Then the rope will connect us so when you barrel down a hill I will too,"

Adora smiles. “Awesome. Still, I know that even without the rope you would’ve followed me besides.”

“God, gross you sap.” Catra says, pulling a face. Even though Adora’s right. Perhaps there’s something soft found in the fact that they can joke about it.

(This is also just. When Catra’s certain that Adora *knows.* The possibility of it doesn’t shock her any more than the certainty does - the way that Adora can joke about the fact that she knows Catra will follow her to the ends of the earth, the way that the promise of that is an admittance of Catra’s feelings. Adora can joke about it because she knows and Catra can laugh at those jokes as a way of trying to make herself feel better. Laughing better than crying. It’s a childish solution as simple as that. Even if it means on days where Adora does joke Catra curls up to her in bed a bit closer. Adora always embraces it, shoves her neck into Catra’s collarbone. Because even if she’s half the reason for the hurt she’s also completely the reason for the heal.)

Adora picks up the rope dragging on the floor behind her and tugs at Catra’s wrist - the action rings, like most the ways Adora touches her, of a night that Catra’s certain only exists in her head - and starts wrapping it around Catra’s waist. They’re so close that Catra fears Adora might hear the tired trip of her heart.

Catra’s about to ask if Adora needs any help when Adora pauses. Her voice sort of blown out,

“Forgot how small your waist was,” She says. “Not that it matters or anything, I just. Yeah. Forgot.”

“Oh,” Catra says. Adora’s hands remain on the rope, paused. Catra feels her skin around the rope grow hot. “Are you going to finish tying it, or?”

The moment breaks and Adora ties the knot fast. She doesn’t move away, though. Instead she stands in front of Catra. Initially Catra trusts that Adora’s going to say something but the quiet

hum of the moment carries on and Catra opens her mouth to literally make any excuse to step away because she doesn't know how much of this she can take and Adora just. Places her hands on the span of Catra's hips.

Adora looks up, runs her thumb over Catra's hip bone. Catra's pulse is all she can hear. She tries so hard to not focus on the way this moment is an awful accumulative nightmare of her wants and instead on what Adora's saying.

"This is it," Adora says, dragging her hands up Catra's waist. They're standing so close that Catra's sure she can feel the press of Adora's boot against hers. "Catra-"

And Catra knows from how Adora says her name that she's about to say something horrendous. Probably address the huge fat elephant in the room of Catra's feelings. Probably ask, in that horribly nice Adora way, kindness and truth first before anything, *do you love me?* And Catra will fall to the ground, or make this awful sound, like she's already mourning the end of their friendship, and Adora will make that same blown out *oh* that Catra sometimes catches in the early morning when she's travelled too far in the night to Adora's warmth. When that happens Catra has the freedom to step away, shuffle away from Adora and chase the ghost of warmth she pretends is on the other side of the bed.

But this time, with this stupid red rope between them, Catra wouldn't be able to move. So she'd have to deal with Adora's ridiculous never ending kindness even in a horrible moment like that, have to deal with Adora carefully rejecting Catra's heart, the red of it tainting her fingertips. She'd hold it out and say *oh, oh Catra I'm sorry I don't love you like that.* And Catra would nod, like she knew that was going to be the answer already because she *knows* it is.

She interrupts Adora.

"Not- not now." Catra head falls. An inch closer and it would press against Adora's. "Please."

She looks up when she doesn’t get a response. She can tell, from the red of Adora’s cheeks and the set of her shoulders, that Adora’s angry. She looks insulted. Catra tries not to think about what that could mean. Adora doesn’t seem like the type to proudly claim someone else's hurt at the fact that she doesn’t love them back.

“Okay,” Adora’s voice hardens, she steps back a few feet until the rope is taught. “Sure. Let's go.”

(She’s ruining them.)

The sun has only just hit the edge of the lake when they step outside. The sight of it is blinding - all its raw burdened energy centred into one place makes Catra want to step inside the house almost immediately. But she hears Adora shut the door behind them and resolutely decides that this is it. It’s a mantra that she itches to start shouting to the area around them to hype herself up. To get ready for what lies ahead. Instead, she says,

“The sun looks tired,” She turns to Adora. They stand outside the house, the wood of the walls contrasting with the chalk of the fresh snow. She feels like tracing the rope with her fingers until they’re closer, her shoulder pressed against Adora’s as they look out at the lake, a fraction of comfort. Instead, Adora kicks her boot against the snow.

“Just like us,” She responds. Turns her head to Catra. “We’ll get to Saul’s.”

“We will,” Catra responds. “Then we won't be tired.”

“No,” Adora responds, the extra fabric of her bandage moving with the wind. She resolutely sets her shoulders. Catra loves her horribly, then. “We won’t.”

Catra watches her for a moment. Memorises the curves of Adora’s face in her mind. The set of her jaw, the snap of her hands as she claps, the sound muted against the gloves. The way her mouth looks - ripe like fruit and pinkish, still kissable, always kissable -

the curve of her legs and the clunky boots that make her taller. Her skin, tan with years spent outside. Everything. She memorises everything fruitlessly.

It’s fruitless in the sense it’s a practice in what she already knows. Catra would recognise Adora blind.

They make their way up the first hill, legs straining with the steepness of it. Adora stays close enough to hear when Catra mentions the terrain change, or how a part of the path dips. They make it through miles like that, trudging with Adora every once in a while scanning the area for sounds. For hours it's absolute silence. It’s so quiet that Catra is scared - she can't hear birds or the usual jump of squirrels on trees and it’s haunting. Adora points it out first, a small, *have I lost my mind or is it weirdly quiet?* And Catra nearly trips from the way it breaks the sanctity of sound they’ve created in the last few hours. They talk about it for a while, the way that they’ve missed the noise of the outside. Adora talks about how her grandma, when she was really really young, told her about birds and where to find the prettiest ones. Catra doesn’t know what to say back, really. It’s odd, that she’s missing that childhood even though it’s one she never had. Maybe that’s just something that comes with knowing Adora best.

They end up passing one of the old houses of another farmer just east of the mountain that separates them. The lights are off and they can both tell from the way the house has fallen on one side that this family left a long while ago. It’s a good message that just because they're further from their usual area it doesn’t mean that the monsters are any less present.

Catra and Adora stay close as they walk around the house, scanning to see if there’s anyone inside. There’s an old red truck parked up out front, but it looks like it was gathering dust for a while. Catra and Adora remember distantly the news of this family leaving - a history of generations spent on the mountains, farming and knowing the area better than anyone. She remembers the way that they found out the news from a rare trip to the grocery store two hours away. How Adora’s face had dropped in surprise,

how she started asking questions about why they left. How the employee, a friend Adora used to swim at the lake with, just sort of turned pale and walked away with a shrug of her shoulders.

That was the start.

The thing about living in the middle of nowhere is that catching news of when things become really bad never actually happens. Adora and Catra were too late. They stayed.

They dip around the house, poking their heads into open windows. They don't see much. It’s still light out but the house is shrouded in darkness. Catra catches onto a few family photos on the walls, describes them to Adora who smiles, a little sad. It’s a reminder that they really are the last people at this corner of the earth. Catra tucks Adora’s hair behind her ear, tries to make her happy. It works. It’s a muted smile, pulls at Catra’s heart until she’s hugging Adora, rope pressed between their bodies. Adora’s fingers find the back of Catra’s head, threading them though her hair. She sighs.

Catra tugs her forward by her hand, away from the house. They make their way up one of the valleys that leads out the area. The snow is stacking up heavier the higher they go. Catra’s legs ache. Adora grabs her hand since there’s space for them to walk side by side. She’s taken off her gloves even with the nipping frost. Catra does the same. Their hands are hot, growing cold against the outside that’s already tainted their cheeks pink.

Adora smiles. Catra’s cheeks turn pink for a different reason. If she was sappy she could say a thousand things about how Adora turns her warm. She runs a finger over the ridge of Adora’s knuckle instead.

They reach the top of the valley like that. Hand in hand, the quiet of the last few hours transforming into stories of hope. Adora mentions how Saul’s is past the next couple ridges. Catra mentions how she remembers how good the waffles there used to

be. They both talk about that morning, a few days after they met, where Adora drove her out to the diner.

Adora talks about how nervous she was because she found Catra, ducking her head and shaking it as she admits, *so cool*. And that she didn't want to mess it up because she was already too excited about getting to live with her. Catra doesn't quite know what to do with that. She spent the whole trip to the diner watching Adora with her mind ringing of the thought, *pretty*. She could say she thought more - maybe about the way Adora's lips looked with the syrup from pancakes on them, maybe talk about the way that Adora spoke excited about the menu and Catra fell half and whole and not at all in love with her in that moment. There's a thousand things to say. Instead,

"You thought I was *cool*?"

"Oh shut up, I knew I'd regret telling you that." She smiles. "And I don't *now*. First movie night and you cried at The Notebook."

"*Okay,* it's your turn to shut up."

They pass two more ridges like that, talking. It's nice. Catra can feel that there's something slowly receding, whatever nasty mean thing that was born from her rejection of what Adora was going to say. It took a while, for Adora to not look angry. At the start of the walk the rope was pulled taught. Now, though? It's hanging uselessly between them. Catra and Adora have never been able to stay angry at each other for too long.

They reach the next house at the bottom of a valley. This one looks just as abandoned - the clean white of the wood walls is a dirty grey, now, and the car out front is absolutely buried in snow. Makes sense, Adora explains, since this side of the valley snows heavier. They trail around the house the same way they did the last one, looking in windows, pointing out if there's anything useful they can find in the kitchen. Catra doesn't catch any family photos. It's haunting, to see so much of a person's life and no person to compare it to.

They’re walking down the front steps of the house after trailing around the porch when there’s a bang, a break of glass. Catra turns to the noise as Adora moves towards her. She thinks, in a sharp but satisfying exhale, *finally.*

It seems that as the winter has grown colder, coldest, the dark of the animal’s fur has grown thicker. Matted too, judging by the way Catra can scan it as it paces around them, taunting. This one isn’t like the last - it’s taking its time, dragging its feet in the snow. Adora’s pressed up against Catra’s back. She’s asking Catra questions about it and Catra’s answering in a barely there whisper - if it stood up it would be six foot tall, the fur is knotted, the eyes are black instead of red this time, it would be easiest to reach its neck. Catra feels Adora’s head move in a nod as she says that last one.

The monster moves, fast, and Catra pulls Adora by the rope from where it was going to jump. Perhaps the monster has decided that she’s the weaker of the two. The wrong judgement, clearly.

They figure out a sort of rhythm, dodging and moving away from the monster. This one is older, Catra thinks. The guess is born from the way it moves - rickety, like a creaky door. Every attack it makes it recedes from, almost like it’s scared of what they could do. This makes her chest swell in pride, in hope, and she mentions as much to Adora.

Adora comes up with a plan, in a hurried breath they spend pressed up against the back of the car. The monster isn’t following them, strangely. It’s pacing around the area in front of the house where they were just at, marking the earth with its indecision. Catra thinks it’s being very bad at being a monster.

They decide on a plan and commit to it. Adora grabs her hand and squeezes it before she leaves. They’re wearing gloves. Catra mourns the false touch of it. Mourns some other things in preparation, too.

They stretch out the rope as far as they can. It’s tugging on Catra’s waist, hard, and she imagines it’s the same for Adora. Then Catra whistles, stays whistling so both the monster and Adora will be able to find her. And the monster turns its head and Catra’s eyes burn with the way the action reminds her of that awful day. But this time, instead of the monster’s neck rejecting the action, instead of the skin ripping apart and blood falling like pendants to the earth, the monster moves unrestrained.

Catra must look like a fucking idiot, waving her arms, calling this monster over. She watches as Adora moves around the back of it, her footfall light. The monster is just before her, eyes hungry, when Adora jumps.

Adora doesn’t miss, oddly. She guesses it’s a combination of Catra whistling some tune she heard years ago and the fact that the monster is making these huge gouging breaths, like killing Catra is something it has to prepare for.

Adora hits the mark exactly where Catra did, all those weeks ago. The difference is that, even with height, and the terrible gagging sound the monster makes of surprise and hurt and challenge, Adora drags the knife down. Cuts the skin of the monster's spine until it’s really bleeding, until her eye bandage is spotted with beads and flecks of blood. Adora, painted brazen with the action. The monster falls, a thud of black against the snow.

“That's for my sight,” Adora says. “That’s for my fucking sight.”

She takes the knife out of the low of the monster's back, kicks its body once. Catra wants to cry for it, then. Mourn it, maybe. She doesn’t know why.

They leave it there. They don't celebrate over its death, or the fact that Adora’s finally got her peace with whatever mean things live inside of her from the forest. Instead, with Adora hanging over the body, chest heaving, Catra taps her shoulder. Pries the knife out of Adora’s grip and replaces it with her hand. They don't look back. When they reach the top of the hill, the expanse

looking over where the house sat, the carcass is just a dot against the white of snow. Dark that seems to be fighting with the purity around it. It's stupid, but when Catra sees it from this high up she realises the extent of things. They've killed, now.

Perhaps it's proof, finally. She'd kill for Adora, has killed for Adora, the same way Adora would kill for her, has killed for her.

The realisation makes her feel sick to her stomach. She turns away, walks. Adora stands a moment longer until the rope strains. They both know there's no point dwelling on things.

They make it past a few more hills like that. Adora washes her bloodied face in a stream and Catra says nothing. The world has gone silent again - no birds, squeaks of unrecognisable noise, no conversation between the two of them. From the set of Adora's shoulders Catra can tell that killing that monster exhausted her. She knows the feeling.

They've made it over another hill, the sun setting behind them which is just a warning of the bad things to come, when Catra's breath hitches.

"What is it?" Of course Adora noticed.

"I can see Saul's."

"What?" Adora moves forward, until she's standing next to Catra. Turns.

"I can see Saul's," Catra knows Adora can hear the smile in her voice.

"You're lying," Adora says, then corrects herself. "You wouldn't. I just. You can see it?"

"Yeah." Catra says. "Has a yellow roof?"

"Has a yellow roof." Adora responds, then laughs. It's a sweet laugh, like trying candy for the first time on a hot day, the tart of

it rolling against your tongue. Catra holds that laugh for as long as she can.

They cross the last hill - Catra pre-emptively thinks that this would be the moment that something jumps out at them and she loses an arm, or a leg. But nothing happens. They cross that last hill and then the next, until they're running through a sludge of wet snow to Saul's, the blue of the diner marking the earth with hope. Catra starts laughing out of pure joy and suddenly Adora's falling next to her, laughing as well. Their feet are dragging in the snow and it's cold but they're here. They're at Saul's.

Obviously, there is the present matter that even though they're here it doesn't mean that they're home. Safe. Still, they're *here.*

The fact alone has Catra grinning wildly. Her ears are cold and she can feel the way her bones ache but they made it. Adora crosses the distance between them. Picks Catra up and spins her around giddy and excited and relieved. The way she's breathing, the way her chest is moving under Catra's hand after she puts her down, it doesn't sting the way it usually does. This moment is untouched from the stupid burden of feelings Catra has carried for months.

They stand in front of the bright blue door to Saul's like that. Obviously there's nobody else there, the diner abandoned. But they made it. Catra presses her forehead against Adora's and smiles, stupid and present and in love, still in love, and Adora smiles just as hard back.

(Catra wants to kiss her. She does not.)

Eventually they kick the door open, the lock shaking with the force of Adora's boot. The cold has frozen the locks just slightly but Adora runs a knife down the gap in the door before she kicks it open, eases the entrance into acceptance. They fall into the diner like that. It's undisturbed, mostly. Like the old couple that used to run it wanted to make sure they treated it nicely even in the action of abandoning it. The tables are clean and there's still

some menus laid out. Adora feels for the gap, ducks behind the counter.

“I remember them having a generator that works,” She smiles, “Worked here one summer. Only reason I remember where everything is.”

“‘S freezing,” Catra responds, walking around the tables. They’re ghosts of another past, Catra scanning the seats and expecting to find that one farmer, or that old lady who lived just past their part of the lake. She tries to not think about how they’re doing.

The lights snap on and Adora pokes her head out of what looks to be a supplies closet.

“They have heating and everything,” Adora says, excited, and disappears back into the room. “They must’ve left pretty early.”

“I don’t think we heard much about it,” Catra says, walks behind the counter. She messes with the register childishly, picks up a radio left on near the coffee machine. Catra moves to fiddle with the stove - surprisingly, it flickers to life. “Hey, the stoves work. God we should’ve come here earlier.”

“I don't know, I’m sort of glad we stayed as long as we did,” Adora pokes her head out of the supply closet. She’s holding something behind her back that Catra can’t see but the look on her face is enough to have Catra raise her eyebrow.

“What are you holding?” She moves closer but instead of falling deeper into the supply room Adora steps forward, until Catra’s just sort of waiting for her to reveal what she has behind her back. It’s incredibly apparent she’s hiding something from how glad her face looks and how she’s standing, slightly angled to the left.

“The stoves work?” Adora asks. She’s practically grinning. The action sinks in Catra’s gut the way all the parts of Adora she loves do.

“Yeah...”

“God this is going to look so stupid if I’ve accidently picked up, like, rat poison or something.”

“What are you even talking about?” Catra responds, smiling. She moves closer.

At that moment Adora pulls out the thing from behind her back. It’s a pancake mix. Catra smiles as Adora jumbles out a fast,

“Okay, *please* tell me this is pancake mix so I’m not offering you something embarrassing.”

“It’s rat poison.” Catra says, just because there’s room to joke about things now. It’s sort of liberating in an awful way that reminds her of when it wasn’t. Adora’s face falls. “Nah, I’m just kidding.”

Adora hits her with the mix, hard. Catra pretends to be dramatic and winces, but Adora just lifts the box further up, aiming for another blow. She drops it after a moment.

“Remember when you were nice about the fact that I’m blind? Yeah,” She says sarcastically, before pushing past Catra to get to the stove. She does it so naturally that Catra almost misses seeing a sixteen year old Adora, working at this diner. Making breakfast for all of the ten people that lived in the area. There’s always going to be a part of her that wishes she knew Adora just that little bit earlier, different circumstances maybe would’ve given Catra a chance. (Probably not. There’s something horrible about knowing yourself the way she does. Knowing the nasty part of her feelings for Adora as something entirely born from her and nothing else.)

Catra steps behind Adora and unties the bandage around her eyes. Adora mutters a small *thanks,* shapes returning to her, and asks Catra to get some of the supplies they carried over in the packs. Rations of powdered milk they hoarded for when one of them really needed nutrients, eggs that Catra found on the walk here near the farmers house that they passed. It’s too convenient

that they have all the stuff that they need but Catra guesses that this is the universe giving things back to her a little bit. Apologising for leaving them so alone these last few weeks.

They decide to go crazy. Make the pancakes in the most wasteful practice of humanity. They've been careful for so so long now.

They end up, dusted with flour, sitting opposite each other at one of the booths. They trade bites of the pancakes - they aren't even that good, dry and lacking something without usually being doused in syrup - but they *don't care.* They're warm and Adora's telling Catra all the crazy stories she has about the summer she worked there, of farmers with weird taste in how to cook bacon and how she saw so few people throughout the day. Of hikers, who she spoke to in an accent, just for the hell of it. Catra laughs, the same way she did those first days after they met. She laughs and laughs and smiles and wonders how this moment will stack up against all the other favourites she has with Adora and then she realises it's useless to compare.

The sun sets. They're sitting right next to a window, Catra's able to track the movement of it past the mountains, dipping its head and pushing its hair behind its ear. Catra, as always, watches Adora instead. Adora's plate is empty and Catra's still has some food on hers and she knows that Adora's always had a bigger appetite than her especially on hiking days like these. She tries not to think too hard, perhaps the brief experience of success has softened her. Perhaps the change in scene has finally made her feel like she can allow herself to do this. She picks up a piece of pancake with her hands, leans over the table so she can press it against Adora's lips.

At first Adora stalls. But then Catra mutters something about how she has extra and Adora's mouth opens. The stupid thing though, the awfully embarrassing thing, is that when Adora finally takes the piece into her mouth after a beat of silence, Catra doesn't move her finger. She keeps it pressed against Adora's lips, heart falling so many steps ahead of her mind, a mirror of the day before.

Adora's face heats up, her eyes grow almost dark. Catra scans the paint of red against her cheeks, something nasty swelling with pride at the truth of it, and starts to think about moving away. But then Adora says,

"Kiss me,"

At the exact same time that the radio blares to life.

Catra jumps with the force of sound against the pulsing moment she created. She tries to turn over what Adora said, convinces herself, in the jump of surprise, hand smacking against the table from where it was hanging in the air, that she heard something different. Still, when she turns to look at Adora her face is red. Her face is red and her eyes are blown out and she looks exactly like the person that Catra's wanted to kiss for a very long time and exactly that person from the night before. The one who pressed holy against Catra's mouth.

She can't rationalise those thoughts against the sound of the radio. The cycle of noise.

This is Base Six. We're aware that there's been some attacks in this area. Unfortunately many of our teams are so remote that we haven't been able to contact them. If you are hearing this, it's a recording. Saul's has been a middle ground outpost for-

"It's Bow," Adora whispers. She sounds fucked out. Catra can't figure out what has ruined her most, though.

-the last three weeks. We send patrols there every two days. This message will, if the owners of Saul's set it up correctly, run every hour. Stay put. Reinforcements are coming.

Bow, Catra guesses, adds the last part sadly.

And I'm sorry. If you have to be someone hearing this, I'm sorry. For making you wait even longer.

The audio cuts. Catra's crying. She can't discern if she started crying from the knowledge that they're not alone or the fact that there's been others. Or maybe a sad part of her is mourning the possibility that Adora really asked Catra to kiss her. She knows how cruel her mind can be sometimes. Knows she's dreamt things similar, woken up hot and ashamed and full of want. What's to say that the lines aren't blurred now? Who's to say that her dreams haven't started bleeding into the world around her? Catra doesn't trust herself. It's as simple as that.

Adora stands up and moves out the booth, runs over to the radio. The message repeats once more before shutting off. Catra guesses the base must've wanted to save the battery by using it as little as possible.

She places it back on the counter. Ducks beneath the counter so she can speak to Catra closely.

"Catra," All the want that Catra imagined is gone from her voice. She knew it was too good to be true. The truth of it tastes bitter on her tongue. "Catra, we're getting out of here."

And because Catra's a fucking masochist or something, because she's tired, she's so tired that she could collapse from feeling, from this. From Adora standing in front of her like always, she says,

"I did promise we'd go home," She has no idea if Adora remembers that conversation (or everything that followed it) but she says it besides. She tries helping Adora remember, even if it's something that will only cut her in the end. "You know, that day."

Adora tilts her head. She looks on the verge of tears but she speaks the next part with clarity.

"Been home for a while," Is all Adora says. She smiles sad, rueful. "Been here with you."

And something in Catra breaks. Really breaks. Like all the times that Catra's heart has snapped have been nothing against the way

it yawns open now. It's a dam of feeling, really. All the different quiet shades of her affection for Adora accumulating into what she says next. She expects to sound hurt, raw, burdened. She just sounds tired.

"You can't, you can't just *say* things like that."

"Why not?" Adora asks. She sounds hurt. Quiet about it, though, like she plans to throw up her defences at any moment. "It's true."

That just makes Catra feel worse.

"Do you do this on purpose?" She asks, scans Adora's expression. She's done with looking at her feet when it comes to facing the big messy bastard of her feelings. "Do you say things like that on purpose? To hurt me?"

"*Hurt you?"* Adora sounds confused, the words striking against the silence of the room. "I would never want to hurt you. Catra. What are you even talking about?"

"Come *on,"* Catra says, she looks to the ceiling then. Trying to stop her tears, maybe. Also because she's always had to face Adora in pockets like this. A glance there to a touch here, shades of Adora to familiarise herself with. "You know. You have to know."

There is a dull part of Catra that is telling her to stop. To shut up before this becomes *it.* But she's tired. And Adora deserves to know. Deserves to hear it from the person cursed by it most.

"Know what, Catra." Adora steps forward, voice shaking. "Know what?"

"It's unfair," Catra says, instead. Builds herself up to the big part by explaining all the nasty things that make it first. "Unfair because, you say things like that and you, you're you, okay? I had no chance."

Adora's silent. Catra soaks into the sound. Finds comfort in it - it's better than rejection, if anything. Catra dully registers what she's saying. You'd expect her to be stopping herself, noticing how her heart is laid out cut open between them, finally. But she's just. Tired, in love, mourning the end of things already. Her voice cracks, she looks to the ceiling again. Glances down and catches Adora's expression before she speaks. There's a courage, there, that she takes from the furrow of Adora's brow. Even now, she's selfish.

"You say things like that and you expect me not to be in love with you? You see how unfair that is?"

She feels the wet of tears on her cheeks, then. The stinging reminder of it doesn't last too long, though. Adora steps forward and Catra's eyes are swimming so bad, blurring with feeling, that she can't exactly catch Adora's expression. But then Adora is pressing one hand against Catra's face, swiping at the wet of Catra's cheeks that she can feel, and Catra breaks. Falls apart. Says,

"See? Even now. Even now you're still you. Still unfair."

Adora smiles, swipes at another one of Catra's tears.

"You're in love with me?" She says. She sounds wounded, shocked, blown out. Her fingers press against Catra's cheeks again, then. She waits for a response, a nervous but hopeful smile on her face. Catra decides to stop lying. Holds Adora's wrist in her hand.

"Yeah," Catra says. "It's kind of hard not to be."

Adora kisses her hard, after that. The angle is a little off, Adora kissing the side of her mouth. But then Catra catches up with the moment and places her hand on Adora's waist, moves her head back so she can kiss the full of Adora's lips. And Adora makes this small sound the second she does it, of want and satisfaction and relief, and Catra feels like crying. She catches the sound, chases

it, wants to taste it again and again and again until it's imprinted on her mouth. She holds Adora, really holds her, holds her in all the ways she stopped doing in the early hours of the morning. Feels the small of Adora's back, the curve of it as she moves to kiss Catra again. Adora tastes the same way that Catra does and there's something dizzying found in that almost domesticity that Catra chases. Dips down again and again.

They break, after a moment. Catra presses her forehead against Adora's and Adora's smile is the same as always. Same as all the other times that Catra has done this. It's a brutally soft truth. This was right in front of her. This was right in front of her the entire time.

Catra kisses her deeper after realising that. Takes Adora's whole face in her hands and claims her, with all the stupid want she has carried for weeks, as her own. Adora's hair is soft, her mouth warm. Catra's dreams could have never gotten this. Gotten the pause before Adora kisses Catra, like she wants to commit everything around her to memory, the way Adora moves to kiss Catra's cheeks, her eyes, everywhere, like she has to compensate for all the other times she's stopped herself from doing it before.

Captured the way she moves back, once, kisses the corner of Catra's mouth and says, honestly, wholly, in that very Adora way of kindness and truth first,

"I love you too."

Catra smiles into that next kiss. She's glad Adora can see it, really, now. Glad she doesn't have to tell her. Not that it would mean anything different. She's always smiling with Adora.

* * *

The patrols arrive early morning. They tap on the windows, hard, trying to gain the attention of where Catra and Adora lay asleep in the middle of the floor. Adora sits up abruptly the way she used to in the cabin, with the noise of monsters ringing around them, and Catra springs up after her. Grabs her hand only to realise that there's somebody waving at the window. Catra runs one hand through her hair, waves back. She tells Adora that the reinforcements are outside. Adora folds and falls into Catra's chest in relief.

They get dressed, gather up the last of their things into the packs. Catra unlocks the door of Saul's and some guy trudges in, sees Adora, and breaks out into a sprint. Adora hears his voice and shouts a *Bow!* She barrels into his chest. Catra watches them, a small smile on her face.

Adora introduces the two of them. Catra smiles, shakes his hand. She can feel how Adora's watching her and decides to pull her in by the waist. The guy Bow stops explaining what's been happening, then. He takes a long look at Adora and Catra and rolls his eyes, turns to Adora and says,

"Only you could find time to fall in love with someone in the middle of nearly dying,"

Adora doesn't dispute it, tucks herself further into Catra's space.

Later, after they've been driving for an hour, the wilderness blending away from them, Catra asks Adora when she knew. Perhaps it's early but Catra's done with secrets. Adora turns to the window, blushes. Her defiance doesn't last too long.

"Just," Adora starts, fiddles with Catra's fingers against her palm. "Don't laugh, okay?"

"I won't," Catra responds, "Promise."

"Okay," Adora takes a deep breath, "Do you remember that night where we both couldn't sleep and like, we had tried cards and whiskey and everything? It was one of the first weeks you were

here. And I remember, I showed you all the personal parts of the house and we tagged your height on the wall. And, God this sounds stupid. I remember when I pencilled in your height your face was just so close to mine. And you were smiling, and yeah."

"That's it?" Catra says, turns to Adora, smiles. "Sounds much less tortured for you."

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, tries again.

"It didn't end there," Adora responds, scans Catra's face once before speaking. "After. After I got hurt, um. That became routine. You would put that bandage on my face and my heart would skip the same way and that's when I really knew. Your face would be so close and I could still feel that same drop in my gut even though I couldn't see you. It sounds dumb, but I used to try and think back on that day where we tracked your height just so I could imagine what you looked like? And then, yeah. I remember thinking one day, after that, yeah. I'm in love with Catra."

"Oh,"

"Took a while, though." Adora says, squeezes Catra's hand. "You know when you said all that stuff about things being unfair? I knew exactly what you were talking about. I had to imagine your face in those moments just to have it. Now that, *that's* unfair*.* But I got over it. Understood that missing your face didn't mean I loved you any less, was any less worthy of loving you. So yeah. If you want the awful truth about it, there it is."

Catra watches Adora's expression for a moment, kisses her once, light on her cheek.

"Thanks for telling me that." She says, squeezes Adora's hand.

"Never thought I would," Adora responds, looks out the window once before looking at Catra. "But you're you."

They reach base.

When Adora steps out of the car, tired, Catra runs from where she got out on the other side. Hugs Adora, hands in her hair, face pressed against the curve of Adora's neck. Adora takes her in. Says things for Catra and Catra alone. Catra pockets them carefully and lovingly the way she always does.

Words are precious. But Adora's? They're gold.

* * *

End Notes

i had no idea that not writing what i usually do would be so rewarding. thanks for reading! have all the hugs ever. just for u <3

by the way the song they dance to is baby this love i have by minnie ripperton! listen to it if you want to hurt some more.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!